

Formal pronouns in Spanish and the case for [HON]

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Abstract

In Spanish, *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all (formal only in regions of Spain)’ have second-person semantics but appear with third-person, or default, agreement morphology. After exploring the possibility that these expressions are nominal imposters, I determine that they are genuine second-person pronouns on the basis of two phenomena: the ability of *ustedes* to occur in pronoun-article-noun constructions and the sensitivity of both *usted* and *ustedes* to the Person-Case Constraint. The question then becomes how to represent these forms as vocabulary items since a [PARTICIPANT] feature alone does not distinguish *usted* from *tú/vos* ‘you (informal)’ in all varieties of Spanish or *ustedes* from *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ in most varieties of Peninsular Spanish. To this end, I argue that *usted* is generated with an [HONORIFIC] feature as well and extend the same view to *ustedes* in the relevant varieties of Peninsular Spanish. Next, I attribute the agreement behaviour of *usted* and *ustedes* to two postsyntactic rules of impoverishment that delete [PART] from the terminal nodes in which verb endings and pronominal clitics are inserted. The first rule is triggered by the presence of [HON], and the second rule, which only applies in Latin American Spanish, is triggered by the presence of [PL]. Finally, I propose a denotation for [HON] that reflects its contribution to the expressive dimension of meaning. Not only does this account capture the unique properties of *usted* and *ustedes* in Spanish, but it also lays the groundwork for the analysis of etymologically related pronouns in other Western Romance languages.

Keywords: Pronouns, Formality, Honorification, Person, Agreement, Impoverishment, Expressivity, Imposters, Spanish

1 Introduction

Languages come to express formality through their pronominal systems in one of two ways, both of which are attested in the Romance family. The first strategy is to repurpose an existing pronoun, as in (1a), and the second is to grammaticalize a nominal construction, as in (1b).

- (1) a. French
vous ‘you all’ → *vous* ‘you (formal)’
b. Spanish
vuestra merced ‘your mercy’ → *usted* ‘you (formal)’
vuestra mercedes ‘your mercies’ → *ustedes* ‘you all (formal only in regions of Spain)’¹

In this article, I focus on the synchronic representation of *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ in Spanish. On the one hand, these pronouns are interpreted as second person, like *tú/vos* ‘you (informal)’ and *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ in (2).

- (2) a. Tú eres lingüista.
you are.2SG linguist
‘You (informal) are a linguist.’
b. Vos sos lingüista.
you are.2SG linguist
‘You (informal) are a linguist.’
c. Vosotros sois lingüistas.
you.PL are.2PL linguists
‘You all (informal) are linguists.’

On the other hand, they appear with third-person, or default, verb forms in (3) and pronominal clitics in (4).²

- (3) a. Usted {es / *eres / *sos} lingüista.
you.HON is are.2SG are.2SG linguist
‘You (formal) are a linguist.’
b. Ustedes {son / *sois} lingüistas.
you.PL are.3PL are.2PL linguists
‘You all are linguists.’
(4) a. {Lo / La / *Te} conozco a usted.
3SG.ACC 3SG.F.ACC 2SG know.1SG DOM you.HON
‘I know you (formal).’

¹Moving forward, I translate *ustedes* as ‘you all’ unless the discussion is exclusively about the varieties of Peninsular Spanish where speakers use this pronoun to indicate formality.

²Stressed, or strong, pronouns require differential object marking (DOM) in Spanish (Jaeggli 1982, Laca 1987, Brugè and Brugger 1996, Torrego Salcedo 1999, Bleam 2005, Laca 2006, Rodríguez-Mondoñedo 2007, Leonetti 2008, Fábregas 2013).

- b. {Los / Las / *Os} conozco a ustedes.
 3PL.ACC 3PL.F.ACC 2PL know.1SG DOM you.PL
 ‘I know you all.’

Unless one posits that features can be added at logical form, *usted* and *ustedes* must bear some kind of second-person feature in the syntax. The task is to explain where this feature is located in their structure and why these pronouns fail to occur with second-person agreement morphology.

As a point of departure, I explore a recent proposal by Collins and Ordóñez (2021) that challenges the assumption that *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ are pronouns. Instead, these authors contend that *usted* and *ustedes* retain the nominal identity of *vuestra merced* ‘your mercy’ and *vuestras mercedes* ‘your mercies’ in that they consist of a noun, *usted*, whose extended projection hosts an unpronounced second-person pronoun. This analysis does not, however, take constructions like *ustedes los lingüistas* ‘you the linguists’ into account, where *ustedes* appears in the same prosodic unit as a noun. At first glance, *ustedes los lingüistas* may seem to be a case of apposition, similar to *mis colegas los lingüistas* ‘my colleagues the linguists’, but it has a different internal configuration. For instance, the type of substitutions that are possible with *mis colegas los lingüistas* are impossible with *ustedes los lingüistas*: *mis colegas Esteban y Laura* ‘my colleagues Esteban and Laura’ versus **ustedes Esteban y Laura* ‘you Esteban and Laura’. Further diagnostics confirm that *ustedes* originates in the same structural position that other pronouns do in Spanish and therefore refute the claim that this expression is an imposter.

To verify that *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ are, in fact, second-person pronouns at the level of syntax, I employ the Person-Case Constraint and find that they pattern identically to *tú/vos* ‘you (informal)’ and *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’. Given that all of these forms have a [PART(ICIPANT)] feature in common, I maintain that formality must be represented syntactically, pace Wang (2023, 2025), or else *usted* and *ustedes* cannot be differentiated from *tú/vos* and *vosotros* as vocabulary items. More specifically, I consider *usted* to bear an [HON(ORIFIC)] feature in all varieties of Spanish and *ustedes* to bear this feature as well in the varieties of Peninsular Spanish where this pronoun expresses formality. I then argue that the use of third-person, or default, verb forms and clitics with *usted* and *ustedes* is the outcome of two postsyntactic impoverishment operations that target agreement nodes. The first process eliminates [PART] in the context of [HON], and the second process, which is only active in Latin American Spanish, eliminates [PART] in the context of [PL]. As for the semantics of [PART] and [HON], I motivate the view that addressee is a unique discourse role, like author, and build this notion into the lexical entries of both features.

In section 2 of this paper, I review the evidence that Collins and Ordóñez (2021) take to support their position that *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ are nominal imposters and show that it is unfounded in one case and indeterminate in three others. In section 3, I examine the architecture of the noun phrase and, developing work by Höhn (2014, 2016, 2017, 2020), assign all first-person and second-person pronouns in Spanish to the head of a dedicated person phrase (π P) that dominates DP. In section 4, I introduce the privative approach to person features that I adopt in my analysis of *usted* and *ustedes* and discuss the interpretation of these features.

In section 5, I finalize the structures of *usted* and *ustedes* and present the rules of impoverishment that are responsible for their agreement behaviour. In section 6, I formulate the semantic value of [HON] and provide denotations for all second-person pronouns in Spanish. Lastly, in section 7, I conclude and discuss several crosslinguistic applications of this research.

2 Pronouns versus imposters

As defined in (5), an imposter is a referential expression that displays mismatching semantic and syntactic properties (Collins and Postal 2012: 6).

- (5) An imposter is a notionally X person DP that is grammatically Y person, $X \neq Y$.

In Spanish, the definite descriptions *el señor* ‘the gentleman’ or *la señora* ‘the lady’ are frequently used as imposters in formal settings. For example, a server in a restaurant could utter the question in (6) when addressing a patron.

- (6) ¿{El señor / La señora} desearía ver la carta de vinos?
 the gentleman the lady desire.COND see the menu of wines
 ‘Would the gentleman/lady like to see the wine list?’

Collins and Ordóñez (2021: 250–251) argue that *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ are both imposters and assign these expressions the representations in (7), where the complement of D is another DP that contains an unpronounced *tú* ‘you (informal)’ in its specifier and *usted* in N.³

- (7) a. Structure of *usted*
 [_{DP} D [TÚ *usted*]]
 b. Structure of *ustedes*
 [_{DP} D [TÚ *usted*]-s]

For these authors, *usted* and *ustedes* are notionally second person because *tú* is second person, and they are grammatically third person because the head noun *usted* is third person. The purpose of the higher DP is not stated, but it seems to relate to the need for the plural suffix *-s* to combine with the entire lower DP, and not directly with the noun *usted*, to derive the correct interpretation of *ustedes*. With these details in mind, I now present the data that inform Collins and Ordóñez’s account.

The first phenomenon relates to postverbal subjects of commands. As indicated by the use of capitalization in (8), *tú* ‘you (informal)’ and *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ can only be overt after an imperative verb if the intended reading is contrastive and these pronouns receive even more stress than usual (Collins and Ordóñez 2021: 252).

³Arregi and Nevins (2018) were the first to raise, and ultimately rule out, the possibility that *usted* and *ustedes* are imposters.

- (8) a. ¡Coge { *tú / TÚ } el plato!
 pick.up.2SG you YOU the dish
 ‘YOU (informal) pick up the dish!’
- b. ¡Coged { *vosotros / VOSOTROS } el plato!
 pick.up.2PL you.PL YOU.PL the dish
 ‘YOU ALL (informal) pick up the dish!’

Conversely, *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ in (9) and the imposters *la señora* ‘Madam’ and *las señoras* ‘Madams’ in (10) can all follow a command without necessarily being contrastive (Collins and Ordóñez 2021: 252–253).

- (9) a. ¡Coja {usted / USTED} el plato!
 pick.up.SBJV you.HON YOU.HON the dish
 ‘Pick up/YOU (formal) pick up the dish!’
- b. ¡Cojan {ustedes / USTEDES} el plato!
 pick.up.SBJV.3PL you.PL YOU.PL the dish
 ‘Pick up/YOU ALL pick up the dish!’
- (10) a. ¡Coja {la señora / LA SEÑORA} el plato!
 pick.up.SBJV the lady THE LADY the dish
 Approximate: ‘Madam/MADAM, pick up the dish!’
- b. ¡Cojan {las señoras / LAS SEÑORAS} el plato!
 pick.up.SBJV.3PL the ladies THE LADIES the dish
 Approximate: ‘Madams/MADAMS, pick up the dish!’

One must exercise caution when drawing conclusions from these examples because, as Fernández Soriano (1999: 1232) remarks, speakers may opt to include *usted* and *ustedes* to “make their attitude of courtesy, respect, or distance evident” (translation mine), especially in situations where they are giving a order to someone who is of higher social status and wish to soften the request. The same consideration extends to imposters, so there is an additional pragmatic dimension in both (9) and (10) that could explain why *usted*, *ustedes*, *la señora*, and *las señoras* need not be stressed. In other words, the fact that *usted* and *ustedes* pattern together with imposters in this context does not entail that these expressions are themselves imposters. At most, the data in (9) and (10) could provide ancillary support for the claim that *usted* and *ustedes* are imposters if more convincing evidence is found in a different environment.

The second phenomenon involves postverbal subjects as well but is no more informative than the first regarding the question of whether *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ are imposters. In (11), neither *tú* ‘you (informal)’ nor *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ can intervene between an auxiliary verb and a lexical verb unless they are used contrastively and are stressed accordingly (Collins and Ordóñez 2021: 253).

- (11) a. Te irás { *tú / TÚ } acostumbrando al clima.
 2SG go.FUT.2SG you YOU getting.used to.the climate
 ‘YOU (informal) will get used to the climate.’

- b. Os iréis { *vosotros / VOSOTROS } acostumbrando al
 2PL go.FUT.2PL you.PL YOU.PL getting.used to.the
 clima.
 climate
 ‘YOU ALL (informal) will get used to the climate.’

In (12) and (13), however, *usted*, *ustedes*, and the imposters *la señora* ‘Madam’ and *las señoras* ‘Madams’ can all occupy this position without requiring additional stress (Collins and Ordóñez 2021: 253–254).

- (12) a. Se irá {usted / USTED} acostumbrando al clima.
 3 go.FUT.3SG you.HON YOU.HON getting.used to.the climate
 ‘You/YOU (formal) will get used to the climate.’
 b. Se irán {ustedes / USTEDES} acostumbrando al clima.
 3 go.FUT.3PL you.PL YOU.PL getting.used to.the climate
 ‘You all/YOU ALL will get used to the climate.’
- (13) a. Se irá {la señora / LA SEÑORA} acostumbrando al
 3 go.FUT.3SG the lady THE LADY getting.used to.the
 clima.
 climate
 ‘Madam/MADAM will get used to the climate.’
 b. Se irán {las señoras / LAS SEÑORAS} acostumbrando al
 3 go.FUT.3PL the ladies THE LADIES getting.used to.the
 clima.
 climate
 ‘Madams/MADAMS will get used to the climate.’

Once again, the speaker’s desire to convey politeness could be the reason that *usted*, *ustedes*, and imposters do not have to be contrastive in this particular context. Another relevant factor, following Fernández Soriano (1999), is that verb forms like *irá* ‘(you/he/she) will go’ and *irán* ‘(you all/they) will go’ are ambiguous in the sense that they can accompany a subject that is notionally second person or third person. The inclusion of *usted*, *ustedes*, or an imposter after the finite verb can thus serve to clarify that the utterance is about the speaker’s interlocutor or interlocutors and not about a third party. Like the examples in (9) and (10) above, those in (12) and (13) reveal a similarity in the distribution of *usted*, *ustedes*, and imposters, but they do not go so far as to establish that *usted* and *ustedes* are imposters.

The third phenomenon is clitic doubling, or the simultaneous occurrence of a pronominal clitic in the verbal complex and the corresponding argument in object position. As shown in (14), *ti* ‘you (informal)’ and *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ must both be doubled by a clitic as indirect objects (Collins and Ordóñez 2021: 254–255).

- (14) a. *(Te) prometo a ti que mañana vendré.
 2SG promise.1SG to you that tomorrow come.FUT.1SG
 ‘I promise you (informal) that I will come tomorrow.’

- b. *(Os) prometo a vosotros que mañana vendré.
 2PL promise.1SG to you.PL that tomorrow come.FUT.1SG
 ‘I promise you all (informal) that I will come tomorrow.’

Collins and Ordóñez (2021: 255) report that clitic doubling is optional with *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ in (15) but acknowledge in a footnote that an anonymous reviewer disagrees with this judgment.

- (15) a. (Le) prometo a usted que mañana vendré.
 3SG.DAT promise.1SG to you.HON that tomorrow come.FUT.1SG
 ‘I promise you (formal) that I will come tomorrow.’
 b. (Les) prometo a ustedes que mañana vendré.
 3PL.DAT promise.1SG to you.PL that tomorrow come.FUT.1SG
 ‘I promise you all that I will come tomorrow.’

Two anonymous reviewers of the present article likewise find clitic doubling to be mandatory in these sentences, as does Saab (2025: 1007) in (16), so I offer the revised data set in (17).

- (16) Ana *(lo) respeta a usted.
 Ana 3SG.ACC respects DOM you.HON
 ‘Ana respects you (formal).’
 (17) a. *(Le) prometo a usted que mañana vendré.
 3SG.DAT promise.1SG to you.HON that tomorrow come.FUT.1SG
 ‘I promise you (formal) that I will come tomorrow.’
 b. *(Les) prometo a ustedes que mañana vendré.
 3PL.DAT promise.1SG to you.PL that tomorrow come.FUT.1SG
 ‘I promise you all that I will come tomorrow.’

As for imposters, there is consensus that *la señora* ‘Madam’ and *las señoras* ‘Madams’ in (18) do not have to be doubled by a clitic (Collins and Ordóñez 2021: 255).

- (18) a. (Le) prometo a la señora que mañana vendré.
 3SG.DAT promise.1SG to the lady that tomorrow come.FUT.1SG
 ‘I promise Madam that I will come tomorrow.’
 b. (Les) prometo a las señoras que mañana vendré.
 3PL.DAT promise.1SG to the ladies that tomorrow come.FUT.1SG
 ‘I promise Madams that I will come tomorrow.’

It has long been observed in descriptive and theoretical work on Spanish that pronominal arguments require clitic doubling in environments where nominal arguments do not (Roldán 1971; Strozer 1976; Silva-Corvalán 1981; Jaeggli 1982, 1986; Suñer 1988, 1989; Roca 1992; Fernández Soriano 1993; Demonte 1995; Roca 1996; Parodi 1998; Fernández Soriano 1999; Luján 1999; Suñer 1999; Bleam 2005; Di Tullio and Zdrojewski 2006; Leonetti 2008; Gabriel and Rinke 2010; Gómez Seibane 2012; Di Tullio et al.

2019; Fischer et al. 2019; Saab 2024, 2025). The need for clitic doubling in (17) but not in (18) therefore suggests that *usted* and *ustedes* are pronouns, not imposters.

Before moving on, it bears mentioning that *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ can be used without a clitic in certain formal registers, which has both a historical and a practical explanation. A wedding invitation could, for instance, begin with the sentence in (19).

- (19) Invitamos a usted a celebrar nuestra boda el día 21 de junio
 invite.1PL DOM you.HON to celebrate our wedding the day 21 of June
 de 2026 a las tres horas de la tarde.
 of 2026 at the three hours of the afternoon
 ‘We invite you (formal) to celebrate our wedding on June 21, 2026 at three
 o’clock in the afternoon.’

In the *Nueva gramática de la lengua española*, the Real Academia Española (2009: 1245) characterizes the omission of the clitic as “a remnant of the former nominal value of *usted*” (translation mine). Not only does the archaic nature of *invitamos a usted* ‘we invite you (formal)’ convey a heightened sense of ceremony, but it also circumvents the awkwardness of including more than one clitic, as in (20).

- (20) {Lo / La} invitamos a usted a celebrar nuestra
 3SG.ACC 3SG.F.ACC invite.1PL DOM you.HON to celebrate our
 boda el día 21 de junio de 2026 a las tres horas de la tarde.
 wedding the day 21 of June of 2026 at the three hours of the afternoon
 ‘We invite you (formal) to celebrate our wedding on June 21, 2026 at three
 o’clock in the afternoon.’

When it comes to everyday speech and writing, however, speakers agree that *usted* and *ustedes* require clitic doubling in direct object position, as indicated in (21).⁴

- (21) a. *(Lo) invitamos a usted a cenar con nosotros.
 3SG.ACC invite.1PL DOM you.HON to dine with us
 ‘We invite you (formal) to dine with us.’
 b. *(Las) invitamos a ustedes a cenar con nosotros.
 3PL.F.ACC invite.1PL DOM you.PL to dine with us
 ‘We invite you all to dine with us.’

In the majority of Spanish varieties, nonpronominal direct objects cannot be doubled by a clitic, and as one might expect, the imposters in (22) are no exception to this rule.

- (22) a. (*Lo) invitamos al señor a cenar con nosotros.
 3SG.ACC invite.1PL DOM.the gentleman to dine with us
 ‘We invite the gentleman to dine with us.’

⁴The same judgments hold in *leísta* varieties of Spanish, or those that use the dative clitics *le* and *les* in place of the accusative clitics *lo* and *los* for animate referents: **(le) invitamos a usted a cenar con nosotros* ‘we invite you (formal) to dine with us’ and **(les) invitamos a ustedes a cenar con nosotros* ‘we invite you all to dine with us’. Since dative clitics do not overtly inflect for gender, speakers of non-*leísta* varieties will sometimes employ them with the verb *invitar* ‘to invite’ in written invitations as another means of avoiding the situation in (20).

- b. (*Las) invitamos a las señoras a cenar con nosotros.
 3PL.F.ACC invite.1PL DOM the ladies to dine with us
 ‘We invite the ladies to dine with us.’

Even in varieties that permit clitic doubling of animate direct objects, such as Rioplatense Spanish, it is still the case that the clitic is obligatory with *usted* in (23a) but not with *el señor* ‘the gentleman’ in (23b).⁵

- (23) a. *(Lo) invitamos a usted a cenar con nosotros.
 3SG.ACC invite.1PL DOM you.HON to dine with us
 ‘We invite you (formal) to dine with us.’
 b. (Lo) invitamos al señor a cenar con nosotros.
 3SG.ACC invite.1PL DOM.the gentleman to dine with us
 ‘We invite the gentleman to dine with us.’

All in all, this closer investigation of clitic doubling with *usted* and *ustedes* echoes the previous conclusion that they both behave synchronically as pronominal rather than nominal expressions.

The fourth phenomenon is possessor doubling, which differs from clitic doubling in that it is always optional. According to Collins and Ordóñez (2021: 256–257), the facts in (24) through (28) are representative of Peninsular Spanish and demonstrate that only *usted* ‘you (formal)’, *ustedes* ‘you all’, and imposters can double a pronominal possessive determiner.

- (24) a. tu libro (*de ti)
 your book of you
 ‘your (informal) book’
 b. vuestros libros (*de vosotros)
 your.PL books of you.PL
 ‘your (informal) books’
 (25) a. su libro (*de él)
 his book of him
 ‘his book’
 b. sus libros (*de ellos)
 their books of them
 ‘their books’
 (26) a. su libro (*de Juan)
 his book of Juan
 ‘his book’

⁵There is a large body of research on clitic doubling in Rioplatense Spanish (Jaeggli 1982, 1986; Suñer 1988, 1989; Fernández Soriano 1993, 1999; Di Tullio and Zdrojewski 2006; Di Tullio et al. 2019; Fischer et al. 2019; Saab 2024).

- b. sus libros (*de los niños)
their books of the boys
'the boys' books'
- (27) a. su libro (de usted)
your book of you.HON
'your (formal) book'
- b. sus libros (de ustedes)
your.PL books of you.HON.PL
'your (formal) books'
- (28) a. su libro (del señor)
his book of.the lord
'Sir's book'
- b. sus libros (de los señores)
their books of the lords
'Sirs' books'

An anonymous reviewer informs me that *su libro de él* 'his book' and *sus libros de ellos* 'their books' are grammatical in their variety of Peninsular Spanish, so there is no contrast between the examples in (25) and those in (27) and (28) for this speaker. The claim that *usted*, *ustedes*, and imposters form a distinct class of expressions is further undermined by the availability of possessor doubling with third-person pronouns and even nonpronominal arguments in Andean, Central American, and Mexican Spanish, as illustrated in (29) and (30) with data that are cited in the *Nueva gramática de la lengua española* (Real Academia Española 2009: 1358).

- (29) a. Porque él deseaba tener un hijo varón justamente para que
because he desired.IMPF have a child male precisely for that
siguiera sus ideales de él y continuara su trabajo
follow.SBJV.IMPF his ideals of him and continue.SBJV.IMPF his work
de él.
of him
'Because he desired to have a son precisely so that [the son] would follow
his ideals and continue his work.'
- b. Mi mamá no debía llamarse Inés Melgarejo, porque el
my mom not should.IMPF call.3 Inés Melgarejo because the
Melgarejo era apellido de su mamá de ella.
Melgarejo was surname of her mom of her
'My mom should not have been called Inés Melgarejo because Melgarejo
was her mom's family name.'
- (30) a. O sea que su mano de don Esteban toca bonito.
or be.SBJV that his hand of don Esteban plays pretty
'That is, Don Esteban's hand plays well.'

- b. Tocó la puerta y salió su mamá de la señorita.
 touched.3SG the door and came.out.3SG her mom of the woman.DIM
 ‘He/She knocked at the door, and the young woman’s mom came out.’

Given that the possessive determiner *su* can be interpreted as ‘your (formal)’, ‘his’, ‘her’, ‘its’, ‘your (plural)’, or ‘their’ depending on the context, the use of postnominal material to clarify the intended referent is unsurprising. The essential point is that possessor doubling does not reliably differentiate *usted*, *ustedes*, and imposters from other kinds of expressions in Spanish.

Of the four phenomena that Collins and Ordóñez (2021) discuss, three do not provide compelling evidence that *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ are imposters, and clitic doubling instead leads to the conclusion that these forms are pronouns.⁶ In the next section, I determine that *ustedes* must be a pronoun based on its position relative to other elements within the noun phrase.

3 Pronouns in the noun phrase

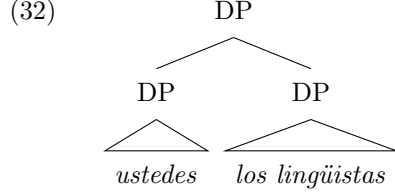
A fundamental issue in the study of pronouns is the source of their nominality, or that which makes them pro-nouns (Zwarts 1994, Panagiotidis 2002). Many researchers concur with Postal (1966) that pronouns are determiners that combine with a silent noun at some level of representation, though not all take a stance regarding the structural details (Evans 1977; Bennett 1978; Cooper 1979; Evans 1980; Heim 1990; Uriagereka 1995; Noguchi 1997; Cardinaletti and Starke 1999; Corver and Delfitto 1999; Elbourne 2001; Déchaine and Wiltschko 2002; Giusti 2002; Panagiotidis 2002, 2003; Elbourne 2005; Roehrs 2005; Sauerland 2007, 2008b; Elbourne 2013; Höhn 2014, 2016, 2017; Patel-Grosz and Grosz 2017; Höhn 2020; Dékány 2021; Höhn 2025; Ilić 2025). This view finds support in languages like English where a subset of pronouns can immediately precede a noun even in the absence of a prosodic break: *we/you linguists*. The equivalent construction in Spanish requires the definite article to appear between the pronoun and the noun, as indicated in (31), but nevertheless constitutes a single prosodic unit (Villa-García 2010; Choi 2013, 2014b; Höhn 2014, 2016, 2017, 2020).

- (31) a. Nosotros *(los) lingüistas encontramos una solución.
 we the linguists found.1PL a solution
 ‘We linguists found a solution.’
 b. Vosotros *(los) lingüistas encontrasteis una solución.
 you.PL the linguists found.2PL a solution
 ‘You (informal) linguists found a solution.’
 c. Ustedes *(los) lingüistas encontraron una solución.
 you.PL the linguists found.3PL a solution
 ‘You linguists found a solution.’

⁶Collins and Kayne’s (2023) account of the syncretism between second-person and third-person plural agreement morphology in Latin American Spanish hinges on the assumption that *ustedes* is an imposter and is thus weakened by these findings.

The fact that *ustedes* ‘you all’ can occur in this environment suggests that it is generated in the same position as *nosotros* ‘we’ and *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ and is, consequently, a pronoun. Still, the presence of the definite article raises another possibility that must be considered first.

If *ustedes los lingüistas* ‘you the linguists’ can be shown to decompose into two referential expressions in apposition, as schematized in (32), it would be difficult to assess the internal structure of *ustedes* ‘you all’.



However, *ustedes los lingüistas* does not exhibit a core property of appositive constructions: compositional flexibility. In a genuine case of apposition, such as *mis colegas los lingüistas* ‘my colleagues the linguists’ in (33), a plural definite description can be replaced by two or more coordinated singular expressions without the need for an intervening prosodic break (Lawrenz 1993; Höhn 2016, 2017, 2020; Jambrović 2025a,b).

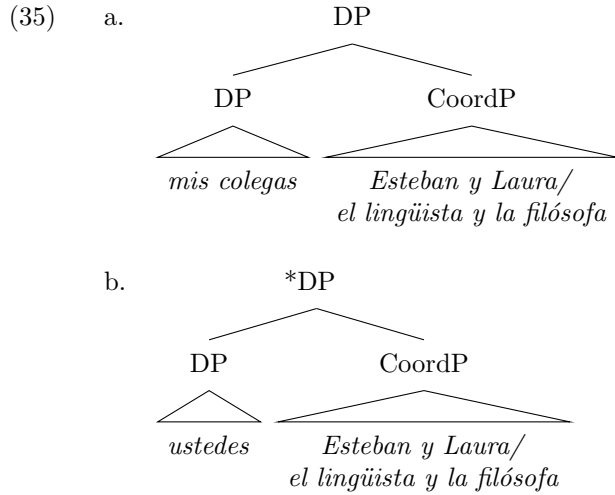
- (33)
- a. Mis colegas los lingüistas encontraron una solución.
my colleagues the linguists found.3PL a solution
‘My colleagues the linguists found a solution.’
 - b. Mis colegas Esteban y Laura encontraron una solución.
my colleagues Esteban and Laura found.3PL a solution
‘My colleagues Esteban and Laura found a solution.’
 - c. Mis colegas el lingüista y la filósofa encontraron una solución.
my colleagues the linguist and the philosopher found.3PL a solution
solution
‘My colleagues the linguist and the philosopher found a solution.’

If one attempts the same kind of substitution with *ustedes los lingüistas* in (34), a grammatical result is contingent upon the inclusion of a prosodic break.

- (34)
- a. Ustedes los lingüistas encontraron una solución.
you.PL the linguists found.3PL a solution
‘You linguists found a solution.’
 - b. Ustedes, Esteban y Laura, encontraron una solución.
you.PL Esteban and Laura found.3PL a solution
‘You, Esteban and Laura, found a solution.’
 - c. *Ustedes Esteban y Laura encontraron una solución.
you.PL Esteban and Laura found.3PL a solution
Literal: ‘You Esteban and Laura found a solution.’

- d. Ustedes, el lingüista y la filósofa, encontraron una solución.
 you.PL the linguist and the philosopher found.3PL a solution
 ‘You, the linguist and the philosopher, found a solution.’
- e. *Ustedes el lingüista y la filósofa encontraron una solución.
 you.PL the linguist and the philosopher found.3PL a solution
 Literal: ‘You the linguist and the philosopher found a solution.’

These data militate against the structure of *ustedes los lingüistas* in (32) above since there would be no way to explain why *mis colegas* ‘my colleagues’ in (35a), but not *ustedes* in (35b), can occur in apposition to a coordination phrase (CoordP) that refers to the same individuals.



Another reason to discard this analysis of *ustedes los lingüistas* is that it would incorrectly predict that any plural pronoun can occupy the same prosodic unit as a definite description in Spanish.

A recurring observation in the literature on pronouns is that many languages pattern like English in (36) and Italian in (37) in prohibiting third-person forms from appearing together with a noun (Postal 1966; Abney 1987; Cardinaletti 1994; Lyons 1999; Déchaine and Wiltschko 2002; Giusti 2002; Panagiotidis 2002; Roehrs 2005; Bernstein 2008a,b; Höhn 2016, 2017; Ackema and Neeleman 2018; Höhn 2020, 2025).

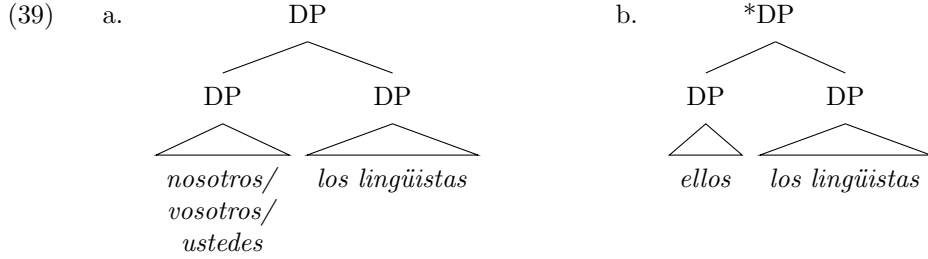
- (36) a. We linguists found a solution.
 b. You linguists found a solution.
 c. *They linguists found a solution.
- (37) a. Noi linguisti abbiamo trovato una soluzione.
 we linguists have.1PL found a solution
 ‘We linguists found a solution.’

- b. Voi linguisti avete trovato una soluzione.
 you.PL linguists have.2PL found a solution
 ‘You linguists found a solution.’
- c. *Loro linguisti hanno trovato una soluzione.
 they linguists have.3PL found a solution
 Literal: ‘They linguists found a solution.’

The same restriction extends to Spanish, as illustrated in (38), even though this language has pronoun-article-noun constructions rather than pronoun-noun constructions (Höhn 2017, 2020; Jambrović 2025a,b).

- (38) a. *Ellos los lingüistas encontraron una solución.
 they the linguists found.3PL a solution
 Literal: ‘They the linguists found a solution.’
- b. *Ellas las lingüistas encontraron una solución.
 they.F the linguists found.3PL a solution
 Literal: ‘They (feminine) the linguists found a solution.’

If one were to assign *nosotros/vosotros/ustedes los lingüistas* ‘we/you (informal)/you the linguists’ the appositive representation in (39a), it would then be necessary to rule out the identical representation of **ellos los lingüistas* ‘they the linguists’ in (39b), and there do not seem to be any principled grounds on which to do so.⁷



Having identified the problems of analyzing *nosotros/vosotros/ustedes los lingüistas* in terms of apposition, I now explore the possibility that these expressions constitute a single extended nominal projection.

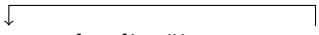
In research on the noun phrase from a crosslinguistic perspective, Choi (2013, 2014a,b) and Höhn (2014, 2016, 2017) both draw a connection between a language’s use of pronoun-article-noun constructions and its tolerance of “unagreement”. Spanish, for instance, allows the plural definite description in (40) to be the subject of a verb that is first-person or second-person in form (Bello 1847, Moravcsik 1978, Bosque and Moreno

⁷Jambrović (2025a,b) proposes that *ellos* ‘they’ and *ellas* ‘they (feminine)’ decompose into four segments, each of which spells out a separate head: the third-person marker *e-* in π (Pers), the definite marker *-ll-* in D , the class marker *-o/-a* in n , and the plural marker *-s* in Div (Num). In other words, third-person pronouns are special forms that realize the entirety of the noun phrase, hence the ungrammaticality of **ellos los lingüistas* ‘they the linguists’ and **ellas las lingüistas* ‘they (feminine) the linguists’ in (38). First-person and second-person pronouns, on the other hand, are confined to the highest functional projection and therefore do not prevent other material from occupying lower positions in the structure.

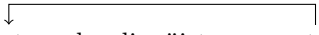
1984, Jelinek 1984, Hurtado 1985, Brucart 1987, Fernández Soriano 1989, Torrego 1996, Ordóñez 1997, Olarrea 1998, Fernández Soriano 1999, Martínez 1999, Ordóñez and Treviño 1999, Fábregas 2008, Rivero 2008, Saab 2008, Villa-García 2010, Ackema and Neeleman 2013b, Saab 2013, Torrego and Laka 2015, Ackema and Neeleman 2018, Di Tullio et al. 2019, Taraldsen 2021, Alsina 2024).

- (40) a. Los lingüistas encontramos una solución.
the linguists found.1PL a solution
Approximate: ‘We linguists found a solution.’
b. Los lingüistas encontrasteis una solución.
the linguists found.2PL a solution
Approximate: ‘You (informal) linguists found a solution.’

For Choi and Höhn, it is by no means coincidental that a pronoun can be inserted before *los lingüistas* ‘the linguists’ in each sentence, as shown in (41), which makes the source of first-person and second-person features transparent.

- (41) a.  Nosotros los lingüistas encontramos una solución.
we the linguists found.1PL a solution
‘We linguists found a solution.’
b.  Vosotros los lingüistas encontrasteis una solución.
you.PL the linguists found.2PL a solution
‘You (informal) linguists found a solution.’

Spanish is a pro-drop language, so all that is needed to account for the verb forms in (40) is to posit agreement with the unpronounced occurrences of *nosotros* ‘we’ and *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ in (42).

- (42) a.  ~~Nosotros~~ los lingüistas encontramos una solución.
we the linguists found.1PL a solution
‘We linguists found a solution.’
b.  ~~Vosotros~~ los lingüistas encontrasteis una solución.
you.PL the linguists found.2PL a solution
‘You (informal) linguists found a solution.’

That is, plural definite descriptions that trigger first-person or second-person agreement are pronoun-article-noun constructions in disguise, and so-called unagreement is, in fact, standard agreement.

One might presume that singular definite descriptions share the ability of their plural counterparts to appear with a first-person or second-person verb form in Spanish, yet as indicated in (43), they do not (Brucart 1987; Fábregas 2008; Saab 2008;

Villa-García 2010; Saab 2013; Torrego and Laka 2015; Höhn 2016, 2017; Ackema and Neeleman 2018; Di Tullio et al. 2019; Taraldsen 2021; Alsina 2024).

- (43) El lingüista {encontró / *encontré / *encontraste} una solución.
the linguist found.3SG found.1SG found.2SG a solution
‘The linguist found a solution.’

The first question to ask in evaluating these data is whether *el lingüista* ‘the linguist’ can be preceded by a pronoun. For all speakers whom I have consulted, the sentences in (44) are unacceptable as out-of-the-blue utterances.

- (44) a. #Yo el lingüista encontré una solución.
I the linguist found.1SG a solution
Literal: ‘I the linguist found a solution.’
b. #{Tú / Vos} el lingüista encontraste una solución.
you you the linguist found.2SG a solution
Literal: ‘You (informal) the linguist found a solution.’

Given that the subject in (43) does not permit the inclusion of a pronoun that would serve as a goal for first-person or second-person agreement, the obligatory use of a third-person, or default, verb form is less surprising than it may initially seem.

The reason that I label the examples in (44) as infelicitous rather than ungrammatical is that there are specific contexts in which a singular first-person or second-person pronoun can be used in the same prosodic unit as a definite description. In (45), for instance, the descriptive content that is supplied by the nouns *lingüista* ‘linguist’ and *filósofa* ‘philosopher’ highlights a difference between the speaker and the addressee that is pertinent to the situation (Jambrović 2025b).

- (45) Puede ser que yo el lingüista tenga otra perspectiva que {tú /
can.3SG be that I the linguist have.SBJV other perspective than you
vos} la filósofa, pero todavía podemos trabajar juntos.
you the philosopher but still can.1PL work together
Literal: ‘It may be that I the linguist have a different perspective than you
(informal) the philosopher, but we can still work together.’

What is unusual about *yo el lingüista* ‘I the linguist’ and *tú/vos la filósofa* ‘you (informal) the philosopher’ is that these expressions have a reading that is nearly identical to that of *yo como lingüista* ‘I as a linguist’ and *tú/vos como filósofa* ‘you (informal) as a philosopher’ in (46).

- (46) Puede ser que yo como lingüista tenga otra perspectiva que {tú /
can.3SG be that I as linguist have.SBJV other perspective than you
vos} como filósofa, pero todavía podemos trabajar juntos.
you as philosopher but still can.1PL work together
‘It may be that I as a linguist have a different perspective than you (informal)
as a philosopher, but we can still work together.’

This observation does not extend to typical occurrences of pronoun-article-noun constructions, such as *nosotros los lingüistas* ‘we the linguists’. Although both of the sentences in (47) are felicitous, they are not semantically equivalent.

- (47) a. *Nosotros los lingüistas encontramos una solución.*
 we the linguists found.1PL a solution
 ‘We linguists found a solution.’
 b. *Nosotros como lingüistas encontramos una solución.*
 we as linguists found.1PL a solution
 ‘We as linguists found a solution.’

Considering that *yo* ‘I’ and *tú/vos* ‘you (informal)’ encode unique discourse roles, I hypothesize that these pronouns can only appear together with a noun if the latter introduces content that serves a purpose beyond establishing reference to an individual, which is precisely the case in (45) above. Otherwise, the contribution of this noun would be superfluous. The larger point is that singular pronoun-article-noun constructions have a far narrower distribution than their plural counterparts, so the unavailability of first-person or second-person agreement with singular definite descriptions is to be expected.

A different concern is how to explain apparent mismatches in person features when the subject is not a definite description, as in Rivero’s (2008: 230) example in (48).

- (48) *Ninguno hablamos varios idiomas.*
 none speak.1PL several languages
 Approximate: ‘None of us speak several languages.’

Quantifiers like *ninguno* can take a plural first-person or second-person pronoun as their complement, so there is arguably a covert *de nosotros* ‘of us’ in (48) that is responsible for first-person agreement (Suñer 1988, Martínez 1999, Fábregas 2008). When this constituent is made overt, as in (49), first-person plural *hablamos* ‘(we) speak’ is indeed one of the two verb forms that can be used (Martínez 1999, Martínez García 2007, Fábregas 2008, Real Academia Española 2009, Demonte and Pérez-Jiménez 2015, Mare 2016, de Benito Moreno 2022).

- (49) *Ninguno de nosotros {habla / hablamos} varios idiomas.*
 none of us speaks speak.1PL several languages
 ‘None of us speak(s) several languages.’

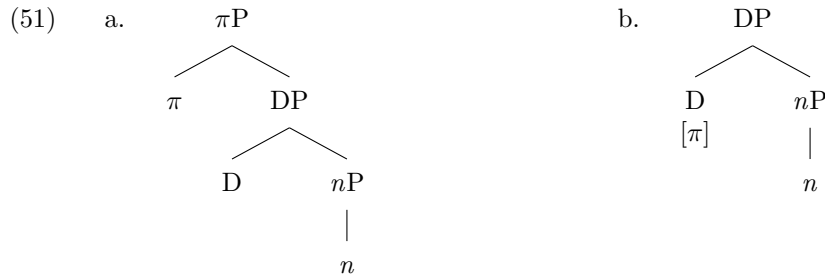
Saab’s (2013: 216) partitive construction in (50a) poses more of a challenge for this approach because *nosotros* ‘us’ can only be added to the subject if it is accompanied by *los* ‘the’, as in (50b), and these elements do not form a constituent to the exclusion of *estudiantes* ‘students’.

- (50) a. *Un grupo de estudiantes salimos a la calle para protestar.*
 a group of students went.out.1PL to the street to protest
 Approximate: ‘A group of us students took to the streets to protest.’

- b. Un grupo de nosotros los estudiantes salimos a la calle para
 a group of us the students went.out.1PL to the street to
 protestar.
 protest
 ‘A group of us students took to the streets to protest.’

At the same time, *un grupo de estudiantes* ‘a group of students’ is effectively interpreted as *un grupo de nosotros los estudiantes* ‘a group of us students’ when paired with a first-person plural verb form, so there does seem to be a silent pronoun in (50a). I must, however, defer a closer examination of this possibility to future research.

Traditionally, D has been regarded as the locus of person features (π) in the noun phrase (Ritter 1995; Lyons 1999; Panagiotidis 2002; Bernstein 2008a,b; Longobardi 2008; Danon 2011; Richards 2015). In light of the finding that pronouns are not mutually exclusive with the definite article in all languages, Höhn (2014, 2016, 2017, 2020) instead argues that person features can either head their own functional projection, as in (51a), or be subordinate to D, as in (51b).⁸



Greek, like Spanish, is a language of the first type because it requires the definite article in (52a) and (52b) and allows for more than one verb form in (52c).

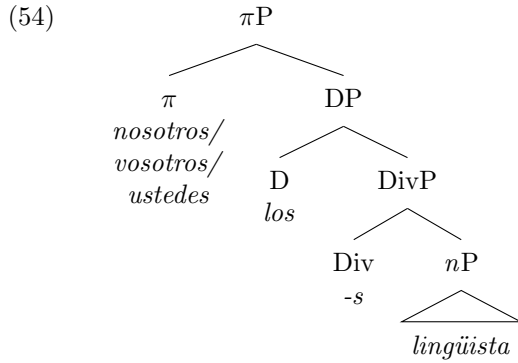
- (52) a. Emeís *(oi) glossológoi vríkame mia lýsi.
 we the linguists found.1PL a solution
 ‘We linguists found a solution.’
- b. Eseís *(oi) glossológoi vríkate mia lýsi.
 you.PL the linguists found.2PL a solution
 ‘You linguists found a solution.’
- c. Oi glossológoi {vríkame / vríkate / vríkan} mia lýsi.
 the linguists found.1PL found.2PL found.3PL a solution
 ‘We/You/The linguists found a solution.’

Italian, though closely related to Spanish, is a language of the second type because it rejects the definite article in (53a) and (53b) and does not tolerate a first-person or second-person verb form in (53c).

⁸Both of these configurations are consistent with Ritter’s (1995: 421) observation that “person implies definiteness, but definiteness does not imply person”.

- (53) a. Noi (*i) linguisti abbiamo trovato una soluzione.
 we the linguists have.1PL found the solution
 ‘We linguists found the solution.’
- b. Voi (*i) linguisti avete trovato una soluzione.
 you.PL the linguists have.2PL found a solution
 ‘You linguists found a solution.’
- c. I linguisti {hanno / *abbiamo / *avete} trovato una soluzione.
 the linguists have.3PL have.1PL have.2PL found a solution
 ‘The linguists found a solution.’

Following Höhn, I take constructions like *nosotros/vosotros/ustedes los lingüistas* ‘we/you (informal)/you the linguists’ in Spanish to have the general architecture in (54), where the plural suffix *-s* realizes Borer’s (2005) division phrase (DivP).



Considering that *lingüista* ‘linguist’ is the head of the noun phrase in (54), it cannot be the case that *usted* ‘you (formal)’ is generated in this position, pace Collins and Ordóñez (2021). In the next section, I establish that *usted* and *ustedes* are both second-person pronouns and motivate the system of person features that I use to capture the various aspects of their behaviour.

4 The representation of person

Although *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ do not appear with second-person agreement morphology in Spanish, there are reasons to hypothesize that they bear some sort of second-person feature in the syntax. If they did not, it would be difficult to explain how these pronouns come to refer to the addressee. The ability of *ustedes* to occur in pronoun-article-noun constructions is likewise indicative of a second-person feature since third-person pronouns are excluded from this environment: **ellos los lingüistas* ‘they the linguists’. Even more conclusive evidence that *usted* and *ustedes* are second person lies in how they pattern in relation to Person-Case Constraint, as I now demonstrate through the standard diagnostic.

In Spanish, dative clitics uniformly precede accusative clitics, and if a dative clitic is third person or underspecified for person, any contiguous accusative clitic must be

as well (Perlmutter 1970, 1971; Bonet i Alsina 1991; Laenzlinger 1993; Bonet 1994; Parodi 1998; Anagnostopoulou 2003, 2005; Nevins 2007; Ormazabal and Romero 2007; Rezac 2011; Pancheva and Zubizarreta 2018). Due to this requirement, which is known as the weak version of the Person-Case Constraint, the second-person clitics *te* ‘you (informal)’ and *os* ‘you all (informal)’ in (55) are confined to dative position.

- (55) El filósofo que mencioné es uno de los ponentes.
 the philosopher that mentioned.1SG is one of the speakers
 ‘The philosopher whom I mentioned is one of the speakers.’
- a. Inés, ¿quieres que {te lo / *le te} presente?
 Inés want.2SG that 2SG 3SG.ACC 3SG.DAT 2SG present.SBJV
 ‘Inés, do you (informal) want me to introduce him to you?’
- b. Inés y Laura, ¿queréis que {os lo / *le os} presente?
 Inés and Laura want.2PL that 2PL 3SG.ACC 3SG.DAT 2PL present.SBJV
 ‘Inés and Laura, do you (informal) want me to introduce him to you?’

In (56), I have reformulated both questions so that the relevant clitics change from second person to third person, and they are no longer restricted to dative position.

- (56) a. ¿Inés quiere que {se lo / se la} presente?
 Inés wants that 3 3SG.ACC 3 3SG.F.ACC present.SBJV
 ‘Does Inés want me to introduce him to her/her to him?’
- b. ¿Inés y Laura quieren que {se lo / se las} presente?
 Inés and Laura want.3PL that 3 3SG.ACC 3 3PL.F.ACC present.SBJV
 ‘Do Inés and Laura want me to introduce him to them/them to him?’

If one replaces these names with *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’, as in (57), the Person-Case Constraint resurfaces despite the identical form of the clitics (Rezac 2011; Jambrović 2025a,b).⁹

- (57) a. ¿Usted quiere que {se lo / *se la} presente?
 you.HON wants that 3 3SG.ACC 3 3SG.F.ACC present.SBJV
 ‘Do you (formal) want me to introduce him to you?’
- b. ¿Ustedes quieren que {se lo / *se las} presente?
 you.PL want.3PL that 3 3SG.ACC 3 3PL.F.ACC present.SBJV
 ‘Do you want me to introduce him to you?’

The difference between the flexible ordering of the clitics in (56) and the inflexible ordering of the clitics in (57) reveals that *usted* and *ustedes* are second-person pronouns, like *tú/vos* ‘you (informal)’ and *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’. In this section, I explore the syntactic and semantic representation of person features, and in sections 5 and 6, I incorporate formality into the analysis.

⁹Adamson and Zompi (to appear) report the same effect in Italian with the pronoun *Lei* ‘you (formal)’.

A major topic of debate in work on pronouns is whether third person is formally distinct from the absence of person. Ackema and Neeleman (2013b: 307–308, 2018: 53–54) take the answer to be affirmative based on the data sets in (58) and (59), where the third-person pronoun *them* lacks the ability of the definite description *the Dutch* to be coreferential with a first-person or second-person pronoun.

- (58) a. Anyone who knows the Dutch realizes we no longer wear wooden shoes.
 b. Anyone who knows the Dutch realizes you no longer wear wooden shoes.
 c. Anyone who knows the Dutch realizes they no longer wear wooden shoes.
- (59) a. *Anyone who knows them realizes we no longer wear wooden shoes.
 b. *Anyone who knows them realizes you no longer wear wooden shoes.
 c. Anyone who knows them realizes they no longer wear wooden shoes.

This contrast suggests that only pronominal expressions are specified for person, hence the referential clash in (59a) and (59b). As the Spanish translations of these examples in (60) and (61) confirm, the same judgments hold in this language.

- (60) a. Cualquiera que conozca a los holandeses se dará
 anyone that knows.SBJV DOM the Dutch 3 give.FUT.3SG
 cuenta de que nosotros ya no llevamos zuecos de madera.
 account of that we already not wear.1PL clogs of wood
 ‘Anyone who knows the Dutch realizes that we no longer wear wooden shoes.’
- b. Cualquiera que conozca a los holandeses se dará
 anyone that knows.SBJV DOM the Dutch 3 give.FUT.3SG
 cuenta de que vosotros ya no lleváis zuecos de madera.
 account of that you.PL already not wear.2PL clogs of wood
 ‘Anyone who knows the Dutch realizes that you all (informal) no longer wear wooden shoes.’
- c. Cualquiera que conozca a los holandeses se dará
 anyone that knows.SBJV DOM the Dutch 3 give.FUT.3SG
 cuenta de que ellos ya no llevan zuecos de madera.
 account of that they already not wear.3PL clogs of wood
 ‘Anyone who knows the Dutch realizes that they no longer wear wooden shoes.’
- (61) a. *Cualquiera que los conozca a ellos se dará
 anyone that 3PL.ACC knows.SBJV DOM them 3 give.FUT.3SG
 cuenta de que nosotros ya no llevamos zuecos de madera.
 account of that we already not wear.1PL clogs of wood
 Literal: ‘Anyone who knows them realizes that we no longer wear wooden shoes.’

- b. *Cualquiera que los conozca a ellos se dará
 anyone that 3PL.ACC knows.SBJV DOM them 3 give.FUT.3SG
 cuenta de que vosotros ya no lleváis zuecos de madera.
 account of that you.PL already not wear.2PL clogs of wood
 Literal: ‘Anyone who knows them realizes that you all (informal) no longer wear wooden shoes.’
- c. Cualquiera que los conozca a ellos se dará
 anyone that 3PL.ACC knows.SBJV DOM them 3 give.FUT.3SG
 cuenta de que ellos ya no llevan zuecos de madera.
 account of that they already not wear.3PL clogs of wood
 ‘Anyone who knows them realizes that they no longer wear wooden shoes.’

The fact that first-person and second-person agreement is possible with *los holandeses* ‘the Dutch’ in (62a) but not with *ellos* ‘they’ in (62b) provides further evidence that these arguments differ in their featural composition.

- (62) a. Los holandeses ya no {llevamos / lleváis / llevan} zuecos de
 the Dutch already not wear.1PL wear.2PL wear.3PL clogs of
 madera.
 wood
 ‘We/You (informal)/The Dutch no longer wear wooden shoes.’
- b. Ellos ya no {llevan / *llevamos / *lleváis} zuecos de madera.
 they already not wear.3PL wear.1PL wear.2PL clogs of wood
 ‘They no longer wear wooden shoes.’

For these reasons, I concur with Ackema and Neeleman that person features are exclusive to pronominal expressions, including those like *nosotros/vosotros/ustedes los lingüistas* ‘we/you (informal)/you the linguists’ that contain an overt noun.

In a privative system, [PART(ICIPANT)] and [AUTH(OR)] features alone are insufficient to derive the four-way contrast of first person, second person, third person, and no person. To this end, many researchers employ Béjar’s (2003) π feature because, as illustrated in (63), it establishes a natural class of person-marked expressions (Sichel and Wiltschko 2021; Toosarvandani 2023; Alexiadou et al. 2024; Jambrović 2025a,b; Sichel and Toosarvandani 2025).¹⁰

- (63) a. [π , PART, AUTH] First person
 b. [π , PART] Second person
 c. [π] Third person
 d. [] No person

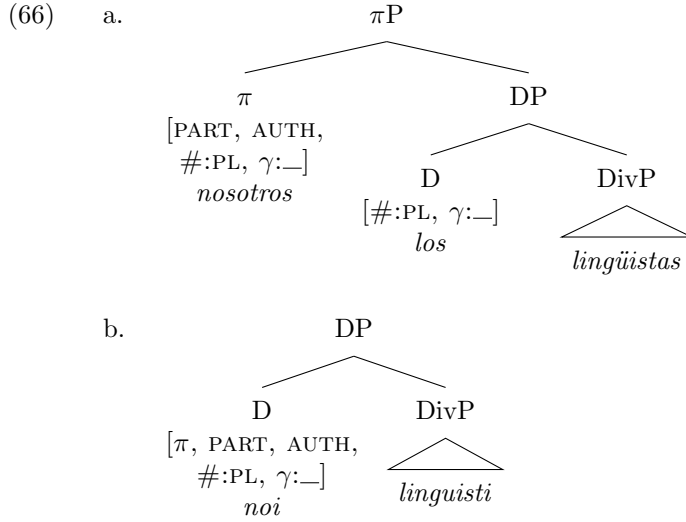
Combining this notation with Höhn’s (2014, 2016, 2017) insight that the locus of person features is subject to crosslinguistic variation yields the configurations in (64) for languages like Spanish and those in (65) for languages like Italian.

¹⁰Similarly, Ackema and Neeleman (2013a, 2018) use a person node, labeled φ or PRS, that hosts [PROX(IMATE)] and [DIST(AL)] features.

- (64) Spanish
- | | | |
|----|-------------------------------|---------------|
| a. | $[\pi P_{[PART, AUTH]} [DP]]$ | First person |
| b. | $[\pi P_{[PART]} [DP]]$ | Second person |
| c. | $[\pi P [DP]]$ | Third person |
| d. | $[DP]$ | No person |

- (65) Italian
- | | | |
|----|----------------------------|---------------|
| a. | $[DP_{[\pi, PART, AUTH]}]$ | First person |
| b. | $[DP_{[\pi, PART]}]$ | Second person |
| c. | $[DP_{[\pi]}]$ | Third person |
| d. | $[DP]$ | No person |

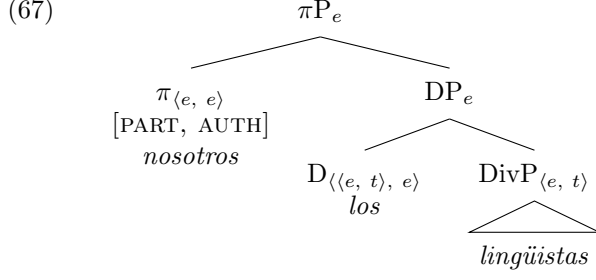
As shown in (66), *nosotros los lingüistas* ‘we the linguists’ in Spanish and *noi linguisti* ‘we linguists’ in Italian bear identical features but have different internal structures.¹¹



Since person and definiteness correspond to the same head in Italian, it follows that pronouns and the definite article are mutually exclusive in this language.

Both *los lingüistas* ‘the linguists’ and *nosotros los lingüistas* ‘we the linguists’ are individual-denoting, or type e , expressions in Spanish, so I model π as an identity function of type $\langle e, e \rangle$ in (67).

¹¹ $\#$ and γ designate number and gender concord, respectively, and $_$ indicates the absence of a feature value. Given that masculine gender is the morphological default in Spanish and Italian and that *lingüistas* ‘linguists’ and *linguisti* ‘linguists’ do not necessarily denote pluralities that consist solely of male linguists, I do not assume that either noun bears a $[M(ASCULINE)]$ feature. Instead, I attribute the use of “masculine” forms like *nosotros* ‘we’ and *los* ‘the’ in (66a) to failed concord, which is akin to failed agreement (Preminger 2009, 2014).



Person features are widely considered to either presuppose or assert the contextually dependent discourse roles of author and addressee (Heim and Kratzer 1998, Sauerland 2003, Schlenker 2003, Buring 2005, Heim 2008, Sauerland 2008a, Kratzer 2009, Jacobson 2012, Höhn 2014, Charnavel 2019, Bobaljik and Sauerland 2023, Toosarvandani 2023, Alexiadou et al. 2024, Jambrović 2025b, Sichel and Toosarvandani 2025, Deal to appear). Using Harbour’s (2016) labels i (“I”) and u (“you”) to abbreviate these roles, I present the mechanics of the presupposition-based view but note that the assertion-based view, first proposed by Bobaljik and Sauerland (2023), achieves a comparable result.

Independently of the structural position that person features occupy in the noun phrase, they have the lexical entries in (68), according to which $[\pi]$ is semantically vacuous, $[\text{PART}]$ presupposes that the author of the discourse context (i_c) or the addressee of the discourse context (u_c) is a part of individual x , and $[\text{AUTH}]$ presupposes that the author is a part of x .¹²

- (68)
- a. $\llbracket [\pi] \rrbracket^c = \lambda x_e . x$
 - b. $\llbracket [\text{PART}] \rrbracket^c = \lambda x_e : i_c \leq x \vee u_c \leq x . x$
 - c. $\llbracket [\text{AUTH}] \rrbracket^c = \lambda x_e : i_c \leq x . x$

In languages like Spanish where person features constitute their own functional projection, the presupposed content of first-person $\pi_{[\text{PART}, \text{AUTH}]}$ can be coordinated and simplified as in (69).

$$\begin{aligned}
(69) \quad \llbracket \pi_{[\text{PART}, \text{AUTH}]} \rrbracket^c &= \lambda x_e : [i_c \leq x \vee u_c \leq x] \wedge i_c \leq x . x \\
&= \lambda x_e : i_c \leq x . x
\end{aligned}$$

The presupposed content of second-person $\pi_{[\text{PART}]}$ can then be argued to undergo the strengthening process in (70) due to a competition principle like Heim’s (1991) Maximize Presupposition (Deal to appear).

$$\begin{aligned}
(70) \quad \llbracket \pi_{[\text{PART}]} \rrbracket^c &= \lambda x_e : i_c \leq x \vee u_c \leq x . x, \text{ which strengthens to} \\
&\lambda x_e : u_c \leq x . x \text{ given that } \llbracket \pi_{[\text{PART}, \text{AUTH}]} \rrbracket^c = \lambda x_e : i_c \leq x . x
\end{aligned}$$

Still, the question remains how to differentiate second-person *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ from second-person *tú/vos* ‘you (informal)’ and *vosotros* ‘you all’

¹²One could, alternatively, take $[\pi]$ to contribute the “potential” to be a discourse participant, in which case it would be necessary to formalize this notion (Sichel and Wiltschko 2021, Toosarvandani 2023, Sichel and Toosarvandani 2025).

(informal)’. In the next section, I examine the complete set of subject pronouns in Spanish and determine that formality must be represented at the level of syntax.

5 Formality, plurality, and impoverishment

As mentioned in the introduction, languages vary in how they obtain formal pronouns: some recruit existing pronouns, while others grammaticalize nominal expressions. Focusing primarily on languages that reflect the first path to formality, Wang (2023, 2025) finds that pronouns that have semantically unmarked features, such as plural and third person, tend to be the ones that are “recycled” for polite address. For example, French repurposed plural *vous* ‘you all’ as *vous* ‘you (formal)’, and German repurposed third-person plural *sie* ‘they’ as *Sie* ‘you (formal), you all (formal)’. Based on a survey of 120 pronominal systems, Wang (2023: 1315) contends that the pragmatic maxim in (71) obviates the need for a morphosyntactic feature like [HON(ORIFIC)].¹³

(71) *Taboo of Directness* (ToD):

In respect contexts, use the form with the weakest presupposition.

Without [HON], however, there would not be a way to explain how π comes to be realized as *usted* ‘you (formal)’ in Spanish or why this pronoun is interpreted differently than *tú/vos* ‘you (informal)’.

No matter the variety of Spanish under consideration, the inventory of subject pronouns cannot be organized into one form per cell if the sole dimensions are person, number, and gender. Starting with Peninsular Spanish in Table 1, *usted* ‘you (formal)’ overlaps with *tú* ‘you (informal)’ in the singular paradigm, and *ustedes* ‘you all (formal)’ overlaps with *vosotros/vosotras* ‘you all (informal)’ in the plural paradigm.

Table 1 Subject pronouns of Peninsular Spanish

Person	Gender	Number					
		Singular			Plural		
First	Masculine	<i>yo</i>			<i>nosotros</i>		
	Feminine				<i>nosotras</i>		
Second	Masculine	<i>tú</i>	–	<i>usted</i>	<i>vosotros</i>	–	<i>ustedes</i>
	Feminine				<i>vosotras</i>		
Third	Masculine	<i>él</i>			<i>ellos</i>		
	Feminine	<i>ella</i>			<i>ellas</i>		

Turning to Latin American Spanish in Table 2, *usted* still overlaps with the singular pronoun that is used for informal address, which may be *tú*, *vos* ‘you (informal)’, or both depending on the variety (Páez Urdaneta 1981, Carricaburo 1997, Fontanella de Weinberg 1999, Coffen 2002, Benavides 2003).

¹³As Adamson and Zompì (to appear) note, Italian is problematic for the Taboo of Directness because this language opted to recruit the semantically marked feminine pronoun *lei* ‘she’ to convey formality.

Table 2 Subject pronouns of Latin American Spanish

Person	Gender	Number		
		Singular		Plural
First	Masculine		<i>yo</i>	<i>nosotros</i>
	Feminine			<i>nosotras</i>
Second	Masculine	<i>tú/vos</i>	–	<i>usted</i>
	Feminine			<i>ustedes</i>
Third	Masculine		<i>él</i>	<i>ellos</i>
	Feminine		<i>ella</i>	<i>ellas</i>

If formality is introduced as a fourth type of feature, as in Tables 3 and 4, the only point of overlap is *tú* and *vos* in the varieties of Latin American Spanish that use more than one of these forms.

Table 3 Subject pronouns of Peninsular Spanish, revised

Person	Formality	Gender	Number	
			Singular	Plural
First		Masculine		<i>nosotros</i>
		Feminine	<i>yo</i>	<i>nosotras</i>
Second	Informal	Masculine		<i>vosotros</i>
		Feminine	<i>tú</i>	<i>vosotras</i>
	Formal	Masculine	<i>usted</i>	<i>ustedes</i>
		Feminine		
Third		Masculine	<i>él</i>	<i>ellos</i>
		Feminine	<i>ella</i>	<i>ellas</i>

Table 4 Subject pronouns of Latin American Spanish, revised

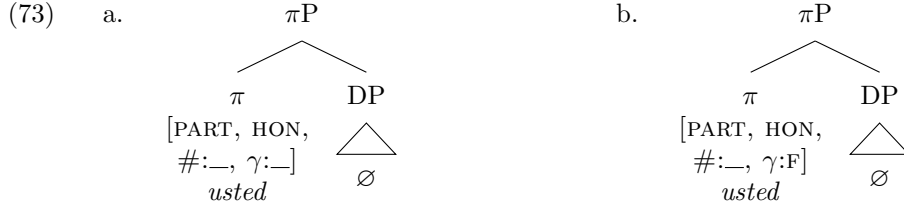
Person	Formality	Gender	Number	
			Singular	Plural
First		Masculine		<i>nosotros</i>
		Feminine	<i>yo</i>	<i>nosotras</i>
Second	Informal	Masculine	<i>tú/vos</i>	<i>ustedes</i>
		Feminine		
	Formal	Masculine	<i>usted</i>	
		Feminine		
Third		Masculine	<i>él</i>	<i>ellos</i>
		Feminine	<i>ella</i>	<i>ellas</i>

In light of these observations, I posit that *usted* bears [HON] in all varieties of Spanish and that *ustedes* also bears this feature in Peninsular Spanish.

When analyzing *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’, it is essential to take into account that these pronouns have both a masculine, or default, guise and feminine guise, as revealed by the possible forms of the adjectives in (72).

- (72) a. *Usted es muy {generoso / generosa}.*
you.HON is very generous generous.F
‘You (formal) are very generous.’
- b. *Ustedes son muy {generosos / generosas}.*
you.PL are.3PL very generous.PL generous.F.PL
‘You all are very generous.’

Consequently, I propose that *usted* has the structure in (73a) when it fails to trigger gender agreement and the structure in (73b) when it triggers feminine agreement.¹⁴

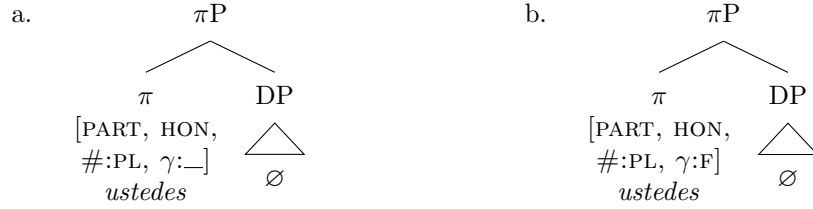


The presence of [HON] on π in each configuration ensures that this head is spelled out as *usted* and not as *tú* ‘you (informal)’ or *vos* ‘you (informal)’. As for *ustedes*, its featural specification depends on the variety of Spanish under discussion. In Peninsular

¹⁴In (73b), γ on π is valued as feminine through concord with a lower head that hosts a [F(EMININE)] feature. I consider the relevant functional projection to be Panagiotidis’s (2019) animacy phrase (AnimP) in this case since *usted* presupposes animacy as well as femaleness when it appears with the feminine forms of nouns and adjectives.

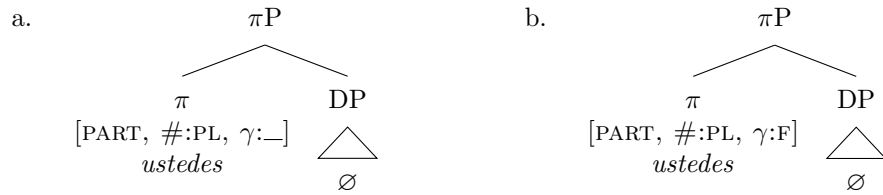
Spanish, where *ustedes* expresses formality, this pronoun bears [HON] and has the “masculine” and feminine guises in (74).

(74) Peninsular Spanish



In Latin American Spanish, where there is but one plural form of address, *ustedes* lacks [HON] and has the two guises in (75).

(75) Latin American Spanish



Common to every structure in (73) through (75) is a [PART] feature on π , so this approach correctly predicts that *usted* and *ustedes* are sensitive to the Person-Case Constraint and presuppose reference to the addressee of the discourse context. All that remains to explain is why these pronouns do not appear with second-person verb forms and clitics, which can be accomplished in the theoretical framework of Distributed Morphology through two postsyntactic rules of impoverishment.

One of the tenets of Distributed Morphology, or the architecture of the grammar in Figure 1, is that phonological material is not present at the start of the derivation (Halle and Marantz 1993, 1994; Marantz 1996; Halle 1997; Marantz 1997; Harley and Noyer 1999, 2000; Embick and Noyer 2001; Marantz 2001; Arad 2003, 2005; Embick and Noyer 2007; Embick and Marantz 2008; Embick 2010; Bobaljik 2012; Marantz 2013; Embick 2015).

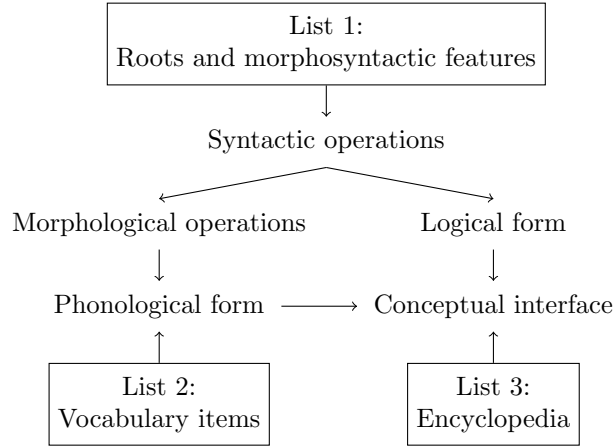


Figure 1 Distributed Morphology

Instead, the syntax takes abstract roots and morphosyntactic features and assembles them into structures that are transferred along separate paths to a morphological component and logical form. Any changes that take place during morphological operations have no bearing on logical form, but they do affect lexical insertion at phonological form. One such process, known as impoverishment, involves the deletion of features and is frequently used to capture instances of syncretism in inflectional paradigms (Bonet i Alsina 1991; Halle and Marantz 1993; Bonet 1994; Halle and Marantz 1994; Bonet 1995; Harris 1995; Marantz 1996; Halle 1997; Harris 1998; Harley and Noyer 1999; Embick and Noyer 2007; Embick 2010, 2015). For example, several authors have attributed the use of third-person, or default, verb forms and clitics with *ustedes* ‘you all’ in Latin American Spanish to an impoverishment rule of the sort in (76) that applies to agreement nodes (Halle and Marantz 1994; Harris 1995, 1998; Embick 2015; Arregi and Nevins 2018).

- (76) [PART] $\rightarrow \emptyset$ / – [PL] Plurality-conditioned impoverishment
(Latin American Spanish only)

If, as Arregi and Nevins (2018) tacitly suggest, formality is one of the features that probes can copy from their goals, the similar rule of impoverishment in (77) is all that is needed to derive the agreement behaviour of *usted* ‘you (formal)’ in every variety of Spanish along with that of *ustedes* ‘you all (formal)’ in Peninsular Spanish.¹⁵

- (77) [PART] $\rightarrow \emptyset$ / – [HON] Formality-conditioned impoverishment

This rule bleeds the insertion of any vocabulary item that is specified as [PART] and thereby prevents *usted* from occurring with second-person verb forms and clitics.

¹⁵The phenomenon of honorific agreement has long been a topic of inquiry in theoretical work on Japanese, Korean, and Magahi, languages in which verbs overtly inflect for formality (Harada 1976; Toribio 1991; Verma 1991; Boeckx and Niinuma 2004; Choe 2004; Koopman 2005; Sakai and Ivana 2009; Kishimoto 2010, 2012; Choi and Harley 2019; Alok 2021; Alok and Baker 2022; Jou 2024; Nam 2025).

This proposal can likewise account for the unique distribution of *ustedes* ‘you all’ in western Andalusia, the southernmost autonomous community of Peninsular Spain. As illustrated in (78), this pronoun can appear with more than one type of agreement morphology in these varieties (Lapesa 1942; Mondéjar 1970; Narbona et al. 1998; Jiménez Fernández 1999; Penny 2000; Fernández Martín 2012; Lara Bermejo 2012, 2015, 2016; Arregi and Nevins 2018, Jaime Jiménez 2018; Lara Bermejo 2020, 2022).

- (78) Ustedes {sois / son} muy generosos.
 you.PL are.2PL are.3PL very generous
 ‘You all are very generous.’

According to Víctor Lara Bermejo (p. c.), this phenomenon resists classification in terms of formality: some speakers may only use *ustedes sois* ‘you all are’ or *ustedes son* ‘you all are’, and others may alternate between the two, yet when they do, the choice of one verb form over the other is not necessarily based on the social status of their interlocutors. That is, the same speaker could utter *ustedes sois* or *ustedes son* in informal contexts as well as formal ones.

I argue that the situation in Western Andalusian Spanish is the result of two grammatical changes in flux. First, *ustedes* ‘you all’ is no longer specified as [HON] in these varieties, so this pronoun fails to trigger formality-conditioned impoverishment.¹⁶ Second, plurality-conditioned impoverishment is an emergent process and, as Arregi and Nevins (2018) maintain, does not consistently apply. As is evident from Table 5, Western Andalusian Spanish corresponds to an intermediate point along a continuum that is bounded by the other varieties of Peninsular Spanish on one end and Latin American Spanish on the other.¹⁷

Table 5 Grammaticalized pronouns and impoverishment in Spanish

Set of varieties	Pronouns	Features	Impoverishment rules
Peninsular	<i>usted</i> <i>ustedes</i>	$[\pi, \text{PART}, \text{HON}, \# : _]$ $[\pi, \text{PART}, \text{HON}, \# : \text{PL}]$	$[\text{PART}] \rightarrow \emptyset / _ [\text{HON}]$
Western Andalusian	<i>usted</i> <i>ustedes</i>	$[\pi, \text{PART}, \text{HON}, \# : _]$ $[\pi, \text{PART}, \# : \text{PL}]$	$[\text{PART}] \rightarrow \emptyset / _ [\text{HON}]$ $[\text{PART}] \rightarrow \emptyset / _ [\text{PL}]$ (Variable)
Latin American	<i>usted</i> <i>ustedes</i>	$[\pi, \text{PART}, \text{HON}, \# : _]$ $[\pi, \text{PART}, \# : \text{PL}]$	$[\text{PART}] \rightarrow \emptyset / _ [\text{HON}]$ $[\text{PART}] \rightarrow \emptyset / _ [\text{PL}]$

Across the board, *usted* ‘you (formal)’ is generated with an [HON] feature, and formality-conditioned impoverishment is active. In the next section, I explore the contribution of [HON] at logical form and the factors that must be taken into consideration when modelling the denotation of this feature.

¹⁶Given that *ustedes* has effectively moved into the cell that is occupied by *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’, it is unsurprising that there are speakers of Western Andalusian Spanish who oscillate between the use of *vosotros* and *ustedes* with second-person agreement morphology.

¹⁷I abstract away from the gender specification of *usted* and *ustedes* in the features column since the presence or absence of [F] has no bearing on impoverishment.

6 The semantics of [HON]

When formalizing the representation of person features in section 4, I adopted the view that addressee, like author, is a unique discourse role. If it were not, one would expect to find languages that morphologically express the distinction between homogeneous and heterogeneous plurality in (79), yet there do not seem to be any that do so (Zwicky 1977, Greenberg 1988, McGregor 1989, Greenberg 1993, Noyer 1997, Cysouw 2003, Daniel 2005, Simon 2005, Bobaljik 2008, Harbour 2016, Ackema and Neeleman 2018).

- (79) a. Homogeneous second-person plurality:
addressee + addressee (+ addressee ...)
- b. Heterogeneous second-person plurality:
addressee (+ addressee ...) + nonparticipant (+ nonparticipant ...)

Second-person plural reference can therefore be conceptualized as in (80) for any pronominal system under investigation.

- (80) Extension of a second-person plural pronoun:
addressee + nonparticipant (+ nonparticipant ...)

After demonstrating that the application of second-person $\pi_{[\text{PART}]}$ to a plural DP yields precisely this combination of discourse roles, I integrate the notion of formality into the proposal.

As shown in (81), *vosotros los lingüistas* ‘you (informal) the linguists’ in Peninsular Spanish and *ustedes los lingüistas* ‘you the linguists’ in Latin American Spanish have the same interpretable structure.

- (81) a. πP_e
- $\pi_{\langle e, e \rangle}$ DP_e
 $[\text{PART}]$ $\triangle$
vosotros *los lingüistas*
- b. πP_e
- $\pi_{\langle e, e \rangle}$ DP_e
 $[\text{PART}]$ $\triangle$
ustedes *los lingüistas*

Ever since Sharvy’s (1980) unified account of mass, singular, and plural definite descriptions, maximality is generally regarded as a component of definiteness (Link 1983, Krifka 1989; Landman 1989a,b; Chierchia 1998a,b; Zamparelli 1998, 2002; Bale and Barner 2009; Gillon 2009; Heim 2011; Champollion and Krifka 2016; Schein 2019; Šimík and Demian 2020; Jambrović 2023, 2025b). For example, Heim (2011: 998) defines a maximalized property, or $\text{MAX}(P)$, as in (82a) and includes this element in both the presupposed and asserted content of the definite article in (82b).

- (82) a. $\text{MAX}(P) := \lambda x_e . P(x) \wedge \neg \exists y_e [P(y) \wedge x < y]$
- b. $[\text{the}] = \lambda P_{\langle e, t \rangle} : \exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(P)(y) \leftrightarrow x = y] . \iota x_e \text{MAX}(P)(x)$

When the definite article combines with a nonplural noun, it returns a unique maximal individual, and when it combines with a plural noun, it returns a unique maximal sum

of individuals. As formalized in (83), where Link’s (1983) star operator (*) indicates plurality, *los lingüistas* ‘the linguists’ denotes a unique maximal sum of linguists and is defined only if such a unique maximal sum of linguists exists.¹⁸

$$(83) \quad \llbracket \text{los lingüistas} \rrbracket = \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(x), \\ \text{defined only if } \exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(y) \leftrightarrow x = y]$$

Next, *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ have the same lexical entry as $\pi_{[\text{PART}]}$ in (70) above, which has been streamlined in (84).

$$(84) \quad \begin{aligned} \text{a. } \llbracket \text{vosotros} \rrbracket^c &= \lambda x_e : u_c \leq x . x \\ \text{b. } \llbracket \text{ustedes} \rrbracket^c &= \lambda x_e : u_c \leq x . x \quad (\text{Latin American Spanish only}) \end{aligned}$$

Both of these pronouns presuppose that the addressee (u_c) is a part of the referent of the DP, so *vosotros los lingüistas* and *ustedes los lingüistas* have the semantic value in (85).

$$(85) \quad \begin{aligned} \text{a. } \llbracket \text{vosotros los lingüistas} \rrbracket^c &= \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(x), \\ &\text{defined only if } \exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(y) \\ &\quad \leftrightarrow x = y] \text{ and } u_c \leq \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(x) \\ \text{b. } \llbracket \text{ustedes los lingüistas} \rrbracket^c &= \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(x), \\ &\text{defined only if } \exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(y) \\ &\quad \leftrightarrow x = y] \text{ and } u_c \leq \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(x) \\ &\quad (\text{Latin American Spanish only}) \end{aligned}$$

Similarly, *nosotros* ‘we’ presupposes that the speaker (i_c) is a part of the referent of the DP, so *nosotros los lingüistas* ‘we the linguists’ has the denotation in (86).

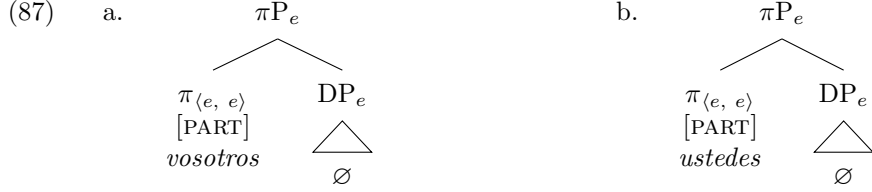
$$(86) \quad \llbracket \text{nosotros los lingüistas} \rrbracket^c = \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(x), \\ \text{defined only if } \exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(y) \leftrightarrow x = y] \text{ and } i_c \leq \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(x)$$

As these constructions illustrate, heterogeneous plurality in pronominal expressions is ultimately an effect of person, one that stems from the presupposed content of [PART] and [AUTH].

When the DP complement of *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ is covert instead of overt, as in (87), I assume that the nominal core lacks a root and is interpreted as Kayne’s (2004, 2008) light noun PERSON.

¹⁸If, following Gillon (2009), C designates the set of individuals in the discourse context, domain restriction could be incorporated as in (i).

(i) $\llbracket \text{los lingüistas} \rrbracket^c = \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(x) \wedge C(x),$
defined only if $\exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(*\text{Linguist})(y) \leftrightarrow x = y]$



The semantic value of these pronouns can be derived by taking that of *vosotros los lingüistas* ‘you (informal) the linguists’ and *ustedes los lingüistas* ‘you the linguists’ in (85) above and replacing the concrete property **Linguist** with the more abstract property **Person**, as in (88).

$$\begin{aligned}
 (88) \quad a. \quad \llbracket \text{vosotros } \emptyset \rrbracket^c &= \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\mathbf{Person})(x), \\
 &\text{defined only if } \exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(*\mathbf{Person})(y) \leftrightarrow x = y] \\
 &\text{and } u_c \leq \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\mathbf{Person})(x) \\
 b. \quad \llbracket \text{ustedes } \emptyset \rrbracket^c &= \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\mathbf{Person})(x), \\
 &\text{defined only if } \exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(*\mathbf{Person})(y) \leftrightarrow x = y] \\
 &\text{and } u_c \leq \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\mathbf{Person})(x) \\
 &\quad \text{(Latin American Spanish only)}
 \end{aligned}$$

That is, *vosotros* in Peninsular Spanish and *ustedes* in Latin American Spanish both denote a unique maximal sum of people and are defined only if such a unique maximal sum of people exists and the addressee is a part of this sum. One can, in turn, obtain the semantic value of *tú* ‘you (informal)’ in Peninsular Spanish and *tú/vos* ‘you (informal)’ in Latin American Spanish by taking that of *vosotros* and *ustedes* in (88) and removing the star operator, as in (89).

$$\begin{aligned}
 (89) \quad \llbracket \text{tú/vos } \emptyset \rrbracket^c &= \iota x_e \text{MAX}(\mathbf{Person})(x), \\
 &\text{defined only if } \exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(\mathbf{Person})(y) \leftrightarrow x = y] \\
 &\text{and } u_c \leq \iota x_e \text{MAX}(\mathbf{Person})(x)
 \end{aligned}$$

The relation between u_c and $\iota x_e \text{MAX}(\mathbf{Person})(x)$ is one of parthood ($\leq$), not of proper parthood ($<$), so it is possible for the addressee and the referent of the embedded DP to be the same individual. In prose, *tú* and *vos* denote a unique maximal person and are defined only if such a unique maximal person exists and the addressee is this person. With this background on person features and discourse roles in place, I now establish that the expression of formality in Spanish is determined on the basis of the speaker’s relation to the addressee and no other individual.

I begin with Ackema and Neeleman’s (2013a, 2018) observation that, in Dutch, *jullie* ‘you all (informal)’ or *u* ‘you (formal)’ can refer to the same plurality of individuals and that the choice between these pronouns depends on whom the speaker takes to be the addressee in a given context. For instance, someone who is having dinner with a friend and her parents would opt for the form of the question in (90a) if speaking to the friend and the form of the question in (90b) if speaking to either of the parents (Ackema and Neeleman 2018: 44).

- (90) a. Gaan jullie nog wel eens samen op vakantie?
 go.PL you.PL yet indeed sometimes together on holiday
 ‘Do you all (informal) sometimes go on holiday together?’
- b. Gaat u nog wel eens samen op vakantie?
 go.2SG you.HON yet indeed sometimes together on holiday
 ‘Do you (formal) sometimes go on holiday together?’

According to Morgan and Schwenter (2016, 2022), speakers of Peninsular Spanish use *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ in all but the most formal of situations, such as when conversing with medical professionals, so I focus on a scenario where an attending physician at a hospital has invited her son to have lunch with her and her colleagues. If the son intends to ask whether those present ever collaborate on surgeries, he would likely use *vosotros*, as in (91a), if addressing his mother but *ustedes* ‘you all (formal)’, as in (91b), if addressing any of the other physicians.

- (91) a. ¿Vosotros trabajáis juntos cuando operáis a alguien?
 you.PL work.2PL together when operate.2PL DOM someone
 ‘Do you all (informal) work together when you operate on someone?’
- b. ¿Ustedes trabajan juntos cuando operan a alguien?
 you.HON.PL work.3PL together when operate.3PL DOM someone
 ‘Do you all (formal) work together when you operate on someone?’

Not only does *vosotros* decompose morphologically into *vos* ‘you (informal)’ and *otros* ‘others’, but it would also be more accurate to translate this pronoun as ‘you (informal) and others’ rather than ‘you all (informal)’ since it does not transmit any information about the speaker’s relation to the “others”, or the nonparticipants in the discourse.¹⁹ By the same logic, one could translate *ustedes* as ‘you (formal) and others’ in Peninsular Spanish. The key finding that emerges from this discussion is that [HON] makes the same semantic contribution in plural expressions that it does in singular ones, which is to convey that the speaker has a formal relation to the other unique discourse participant, the addressee.

The next issue to explore is whether [HON] is a presupposition trigger, like [PART] and [AUTH], and the most straightforward way to test for this possibility is to evaluate whether the interpretation of *usted* ‘you (formal)’ is affected by the presence of material that interacts with presupposed content. In (92), the propositional attitude verbs *cree* ‘believes’ and *teme* ‘fears’ alter the presupposition that is introduced by the definite description *el león* ‘the lion’ such that each sentence as a whole only presupposes that the subject believes that there is a unique maximal lion in the discourse context (Karttunen 1974, Heim 1992, Zeevat 1992, Rullmann and Beck 1998, Yeom 2003, Amaral 2019).

¹⁹Speakers of Old Spanish began to use *vos* ‘you all’ for singular formal address much like speakers of French use *vous* ‘you all’ for this purpose (Lapesa 1942, Páez Urdaneta 1981, Penny 1991, Rini 1999, Penny 2000, Bentivoglio 2003, Pharies 2007). However, *vos* lost its honorific status over time, and *otros* was added to disambiguate plural reference from singular reference. Through a process of grammaticalization, *vosotros* eventually replaced *vos* in the plural paradigm, and *nosotros* ‘we’ came to replace *nos* ‘we’ by analogy.

- (92) a. Esteban cree que el león lo vio.
 Esteban believes that the lion 3SG.ACC saw.3SG
 ‘Esteban believes that the lion saw him.’
 b. Esteban teme que el león lo viera.
 Esteban fears that the lion 3SG.ACC saw.SBJV
 ‘Esteban fears that the lion saw him.’

This characterization of *cree* and *teme* is supported by the fact that the existence of the lion can be negated in both cases, as illustrated in (93).

- (93) a. Esteban cree que el león lo vio, pero no hay ningún
 Esteban believes that the lion 3SG.ACC saw.3SG but not has no
 león.
 lion
 ‘Esteban believes that the lion saw him, but there is no lion.’
 b. Esteban teme que el león lo viera, pero no hay ningún león.
 Esteban fears that the lion 3SG.ACC saw.SBJV but not has no lion
 ‘Esteban fears that the lion saw him, but there is no lion.’

If *usted* were to presuppose that the speaker’s relation to the addressee is formal, the examples in (94) should presuppose that the subject believes that this relation holds between the speaker and the addressee, yet neither one permits such an inference.

- (94) a. Esteban cree que usted lo vio.
 Esteban believes that you.HON 3SG.ACC saw.3SG
 ‘Esteban believes that you (formal) saw him.’
 b. Esteban teme que usted lo viera.
 Esteban fears that you.HON 3SG.ACC saw.SBJV
 ‘Esteban fears that you (formal) saw him.’

These data reveal that formality is not interpreted within the scope of intensional operators and thus rule out a presupposition-based analysis of [HON].

Many researchers argue that formality pertains to a separate dimension of meaning, that of expressive content, because it can only be assessed with respect to the utterance situation and always reflects the perspective of the speaker (Potts and Kawahara 2004, Potts 2005, Horn 2007, Kim and Sells 2007, Potts 2007, McCready 2010, Gutzmann 2013, Amaral 2019, Gutzmann 2019, McCready 2019, Saab 2025). In recent work on Rioplatense Spanish, Saab (2025: 1008) remarks that *usted* ‘you (formal)’ could have the semantic value in (95a), which is based on Potts’s (2007) treatment of formal pronouns, or that in (95b), which is based on McCready’s (2010, 2019).²⁰

- (95) a. $\llbracket \text{FORMAL}(usted_1) \rrbracket^{g,c} = g(1) \bullet \text{Formal}(i_c, u_c)$
 b. $\llbracket usted_1 \rrbracket^{g,c} = g(1) \blacklozenge \text{Formal}(i_c, u_c)$

²⁰I have modified these formalisms so that they are consistent with Heim and Kratzer’s (1998) pronouns and traces rule and use the same notation for speaker (i_c) and addressee (u_c) that is found elsewhere in this paper.

The difference between these two views is that formality is contributed by a feature that applies to *usted* in (95a) and by the pronoun itself in (95b). Given that formality, or [HON], is the sole feature that distinguishes *usted* from *tú/vos* ‘you (informal)’, the approach in (95a) does not seem viable. If one were to conceive of number in the same way, it would be akin to defending the analysis of *lingüistas* ‘linguists’ in (96a) instead of that in (96b).

- (96) a. $\llbracket \text{PLURAL}(\textit{lingüistas}) \rrbracket = \lambda x_e . * \text{Linguist}(x)$
b. $\llbracket \textit{lingüistas} \rrbracket = \lambda x_e . * \text{Linguist}(x)$

For this reason, I adopt McCready’s system and propose the lexical entry in (97) for [HON] as a privative feature.

- (97) $\llbracket [\text{HON}] \rrbracket^c = \lambda x_e . x \blacklozenge \text{Formal}(i_c, u_c)$

The denotation of second-person $\pi_{[\text{PART}, \text{HON}]}$ can then be generated by uniting the descriptive content of [PART] with the expressive content of [HON], as in (98).

- (98) $\llbracket \pi_{[\text{PART}, \text{HON}]} \rrbracket^c = \lambda x_e : u_c \leq x . x \blacklozenge \text{Formal}(i_c, u_c)$

This head yields the semantic value in (99a) for *usted* in all varieties of Spanish and that in (99b) for *ustedes* ‘you all (formal)’ in Peninsular Spanish.

- (99) a. $\llbracket \textit{usted} \varnothing \rrbracket^c = \iota x_e \text{MAX}(\text{Person})(x) \blacklozenge \text{Formal}(i_c, u_c),$
defined only if $\exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(\text{Person})(y) \leftrightarrow x = y]$
and $u_c \leq \iota x_e \text{MAX}(\text{Person})(x)$
b. $\llbracket \textit{ustedes} \varnothing \rrbracket^c = \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Person})(x) \blacklozenge \text{Formal}(i_c, u_c),$
defined only if $\exists x_e \forall y_e [\text{MAX}(*\text{Person})(y) \leftrightarrow x = y]$
and $u_c \leq \iota x_e \text{MAX}(*\text{Person})(x)$
(Peninsular Spanish only)

In the descriptive dimension, *usted* and *ustedes* presuppose that the addressee is part of the referent of their DP complement, and in the expressive dimension, they convey that the speaker’s relation to the addressee is formal. Rather than posit that *tú/vos* and *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ include an expressive component as well, I follow a suggestion by McCready and invoke Gricean logic to account for their informal readings. If a speaker uses *tú/vos* or *vosotros* in a given situation, one can infer that this individual does not find *usted* or *ustedes* to be appropriate for that situation and, by extension, does not consider formality to be necessary or warranted.

7 Conclusion

The objective of this article has been to explore the syntactic identity of *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’, and I have determined that these expressions are fully grammaticalized pronouns on the basis of three phenomena. First, *usted* and *ustedes* require clitic doubling in object position, as do all stressed pronouns in Spanish. Second, *ustedes* can occur in an environment that only tolerates first-person

and second-person pronouns: *nosotros/vosotros/ustedes los lingüistas* ‘we/you (informal)/you the linguists’. Third, and most telling of all, *usted* and *ustedes* are both sensitive to the Person-Case Constraint, a finding that not only confirms that these pronouns are second person but also raises the question of how to differentiate them from *tú/vos* ‘you (informal)’ and *vosotros* ‘you all (informal)’ as vocabulary items. To resolve this issue, I assigned an [HON] feature to the syntactic representation of *usted* in all varieties of Spanish as well as that of *ustedes* in the varieties of Peninsular Spanish where speakers use this expression to indicate formality. Next, I formulated two post-syntactic rules of impoverishment that eliminate [PART] from agreement nodes and prevent *usted* and *ustedes* from appearing with second-person verb forms and clitics. The first rule, which is universally active, applies in the context of [HON], and the second rule, which is only active in Latin American Spanish, applies in the context of [PL]. Finally, I motivated the claim that addressee is a unique discourse role and composed a lexical entry for [HON] that captures the expressive semantics of this feature.

Among the Western Romance languages, Spanish is not unique in having expanded its pronominal inventory by grammaticalizing a set of nominal expressions. As shown in (100), the equivalent of *vuestra merced* ‘your mercy’ and *vuestras mercedes* ‘your mercies’ in Catalan and Portuguese followed a similar evolutionary path.²¹

- (100) a. Catalan
vostra mercè ‘your mercy’ → *vostè* ‘you (formal)’
vostres mercès ‘your mercies’ → *vostès* ‘you all (formal)’
 b. Portuguese
vossa mercê ‘your mercy’ → *você* ‘you (semiformal in Portugal and regions of Brazil)’
vossas mercês ‘your mercies’ → *vocês* ‘you all’

Like *usted* ‘you (formal)’ and *ustedes* ‘you all’ in Spanish, these forms exhibit contrasting semantic and syntactic properties in (101) through (103).

- (101) Catalan
 a. Vostè {és / *ets} lingüista.
 you.HON is are.2SG linguist
 ‘You (formal) are a linguist.’
 b. Vostès {són / *sou} lingüistas.
 you.HON.PL are.3PL are.2PL linguists
 ‘You all (formal) are linguists.’
 (102) European Portuguese/Brazilian Portuguese A
 a. Você {é / *és} linguista.
 you.HON is are.2SG linguist
 ‘You (semiformal) are a linguist.’

²¹In (100b), I translate *você* as ‘you (semiformal)’ because speakers of Portuguese frequently employ the imposters *o senhor* ‘the gentleman’ and *a senhora* ‘the lady’ to impart an even greater degree of formality.

- b. Vocês {são / *sois} linguistas.
 you.PL are.3PL are.2PL linguists
 ‘You all are linguists.’
- (103) Brazilian Portuguese B
- a. Você {é / *és} linguista.
 you is are.2SG linguist
 ‘You are a linguist.’
- b. Vocês {são / *sois} linguistas.
 you.PL are.3PL are.2PL linguists
 ‘You all are linguists.’

The empirical landscape in Brazil is not easily defined in geographical terms, so I resort to the more abstract labels “Brazilian Portuguese A” and “Brazilian Portuguese B” to distinguish varieties where *você* ‘you (semiformal)’ coexists with *tu* ‘you (informal)’ from varieties where *você* ‘you’ is the only singular form of address. In Table 6, I identify the relevant features of the heads where these second-person pronouns are inserted and provide the impoverishment rules that explain their agreement behaviour.

Table 6 Grammaticalized pronouns and impoverishment in Western Romance

Language or set of varieties	Pronouns	Features	Impoverishment rules
Catalan	<i>vostè</i>	$[\pi, \text{PART}, \text{HON}, \#:_]$	$[\text{PART}] \rightarrow \emptyset / _ [\text{HON}]$
	<i>vostès</i>	$[\pi, \text{PART}, \text{HON}, \#:\text{PL}]$	
European Portuguese/ Brazilian Portuguese A	<i>você</i>	$[\pi, \text{PART}, \text{HON}, \#:_]$	$[\text{PART}] \rightarrow \emptyset / _ [\text{HON}]$ $[\text{PART}] \rightarrow \emptyset / _ [\text{PL}]$
	<i>vocês</i>	$[\pi, \text{PART}, \#:\text{PL}]$	
Brazilian Portuguese B	<i>você</i>	$[\pi, \text{PART}, \#:_]$	$[\text{PART}] \rightarrow \emptyset$
	<i>vocês</i>	$[\pi, \text{PART}, \#:\text{PL}]$	

Catalan is comparable to Peninsular Spanish in that it only has formality-conditioned impoverishment, while European Portuguese and Brazilian Portuguese A are comparable to Latin American Spanish in that they have both formality-conditioned and plurality-conditioned impoverishment. As for Brazilian Portuguese B, I hypothesize that $[\text{PART}]$ is uniformly eliminated from agreement nodes in these varieties.

To briefly speak to languages that have repurposed existing pronouns for formal address, one topic that has yet to be explored is whether these derived honorifics are syntactically identical to their source forms. In German, for example, *Sie* ‘you (formal), you all (formal)’ and *sie* ‘they’ appear with the same verb form in (104), but only *Sie* can occupy the pronoun-noun construction in (105).

- (104) a. Haben Sie eine Lösung gefunden?
 have you.HON a solution found
 ‘Have you (formal)/you all (formal) found a solution?’

- b. Haben sie eine Lösung gefunden?
have they a solution found
'Have they found a solution?'
- (105)
- a. Haben Sie Linguisten eine Lösung gefunden?
have you.HON linguists a solution found
'Have you (formal) linguists found a solution?'
 - b. *Haben sie Linguisten eine Lösung gefunden?
have they linguists a solution found
Literal: 'Have they linguists found a solution?'

These facts suggest that *Sie* acquired a [PART] feature at some point during the course of its development into a formal pronoun, just as *usted* 'you (formal)' and *ustedes* 'you all' did in Spanish. The analogy can be taken even further in that *Sie* would have also needed to obtain an [HON] feature to be differentiable from *ihr* 'you all (informal)' as a vocabulary item, in which case the insertion of default plural *haben* 'have' instead of second-person plural *habt* '(you all) have' in (105a) could be attributed to formality-conditioned impoverishment. Far more investigation into this possibility is required, but this initial foray into the featural composition of *Sie* demonstrates that this pronoun could, in principle, be analyzed similarly to *usted* and *ustedes*.

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